OBITUARIES

Edwin Van Sciver, 91, designer, sailing enthusiast

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Edwin P. Van Sciver, 91, an architectural and product designer and sailing enthusiast, died of heart failure Tuesday, Aug. 17, at Waverly Heights, a retirement community in Gladwyne.

Mr. Van Sciver earned a bachelor's degree in engineering and fine arts from the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in 1942. During World War II, he worked in California for what later became the McDonnell Douglas Corp.

After the war, he returned to his hometown of Philadelphia and operated an industrial-design firm with his three brothers for several years. He then was a product designer for Philco Corp. In 1972, he joined Narco Scientific in Fort Washington, a manufacturer of technical instruments. He headed its marine division and developed an emergency radio beacon for offshore sailors, said his son, Rodman.

Mr. Van Sciver retired from Narco in 1975 and became an architectural designer for homes and remodeling projects.

He had some background experience for his new career, his son said. In the 1950s he won an award from Better Homes & Gardens magazine for a swimming pool he designed at his home in Roxborough, and in 1961 he designed and built a house for his family in Chestnut Hill. "He could fix or build anything," his son said, and he also enjoyed gardening and landscape design.

Mr. Van Sciver built two sneakbox sailboats in shop class at Germantown Friends School and won regattas in Toms River, N.J., sailing them. He and a brother, Wesley, spent the summer sailing a 38-foot cutter when he was in college. While his son was growing up, Mr. Van Sciver sailed Lightning–class boats in Barnegat Bay, N.J. Later, he sailed in the Grand Cayman Islands, where he and his wife had a winter home. Mr. Van Sciver's wife, Sally Walter Van Sciver, died in 2001. They had met when they were in third grade at Germantown Friends. They married in 1941.

In addition to his son, Mr. Van Sciver is survived by two grandchildren. His close friend and companion, Mona McLane, died last year.

A memorial service will be held at 1 p.m. Sunday, Aug. 22, at St. Thomas Church, Whitemarsh, 600 Bethlehem Pike in Flourtown. Memorial donations may be made to Education for All

Children, 11 Heather Dr., Rye, N.H. 03870. The foundation, which the Van Sciver family established, provides scholarships to children in the developing world.

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